

HARE: Compact HQC via Distance-Informed Erasure Decoding

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Abstract. We present HARE, a KEM scheme based on the HQC framework with reduced public key and ciphertext sizes. The core idea is to introduce a distance-informed erasure decoding technique for the concatenated code: leveraging distance information from the inner code to identify unreliable blocks and treat them as erasures, which are then corrected by the outer code. We further refine the ciphertext compression method of Bitzer et al. in EUROCRYPT 2026 by incorporating covering codes. Combining these techniques with refined parameter choices, we achieve a lower decryption failure rate, enabling more compact parameters. Compared to HQC, HARE reduces the combined size of public key and ciphertext by 13.7%, 14.0%, and 14.3% for NIST security levels 1, 3, and 5, respectively.

Keywords: Post-Quantum Cryptography · Code-Based Cryptography · Hamming Quasi-Cyclic · HARE · Erasure Decoding · Covering Codes

1 Introduction

The development of quantum algorithms such as Shor’s algorithm [19] has made the transition to post-quantum cryptography (PQC) inevitable. In 2016, the National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST) initiated a process to standardize post-quantum public-key cryptography [1]. Code-based cryptography plays an important role in this effort, and in 2025, the Hamming Quasi-Cyclic (HQC) scheme [16] was selected as the first code-based standard for PQC.

While HQC offers a reliable decryption failure rate (DFR) estimation, its practical performance is hindered by larger public key and ciphertext sizes compared to lattice-based encryption schemes such as Kyber [4]. Consequently, optimizing the communication overhead (i.e., the public key and ciphertext sizes) of code-based schemes without compromising security and DFR has become a pressing research

In this work, we present **HARE**, an optimized HQC-like encryption scheme that maintains provable security and DFR under the original HQC assumptions while achieving a substantial reduction in communication overhead. Compared to the original HQC, our parameter choices demonstrate that HARE reduces the combined size of the public key and ciphertext by 13.7%, 14.0%, and 14.3% for NIST security levels 1, 3, and 5, respectively.

Our main improvement comes from a refined decoding strategy that leverages *erasure error correction* during the decryption process. HQC employs a concatenated code structure combining Reed-Muller and Reed-Solomon codes to encode the message. The decoding procedure for this concatenated code proceeds in two stages: first, minimum-distance decoding is applied to the Reed-Muller code to correct bit flips in local blocks of the input noisy vector; second, the Reed-Solomon decoder treats each local block as a symbol and corrects any blocks that remain erroneous after the first stage, thereby recovering the original message.

In our approach, we observed that additional information can be extracted during the Reed-Muller decoding stage. Specifically, the distance between the input vector (restricted to a local block) and the nearest Reed-Muller codeword provides a useful hint about the reliability of the decoding result. If the decoding output has relatively low confidence, we erase that block and treat the corresponding position as an erasure during the subsequent Reed-Solomon decoding. We then employ an erasure-tolerant decoding algorithm for the Reed-Solomon code.

With this improved decoding strategy, we obtain a more effective decoding procedure that provably achieves a significantly lower DFR for a given set of code parameters. This allows us to reduce the length of the concatenated code while still meeting the DFR requirements for the same security level as HQC, leading to a reduction in the overall sizes of the public key and ciphertext.

Another contribution of our work is to reinterpret the ciphertext compression technique in [3] from the perspective of covering codes. At a high level, the compression technique can be viewed as mapping a random vector to a nearby codeword, where a shorter representation is used to reduce bandwidth at the cost of introducing noise. Therefore, the code length needs to be increased to improve the error tolerance, while achieving an overall bandwidth reduction requires a careful parameter trade-off. From the traditional perspective of error-correcting codes, the choice of compression codes is highly restricted, which limits the design space. In contrast, adopting the viewpoint of covering codes significantly broadens the range of possible constructions. Building on this insight, we explore candidate covering codes in [5] and identify the Kaikkonen-Rosendahl (KR) code

as a suitable choice for ciphertext compression, leading to a smaller bandwidth compared to the use of Hamming and Golay codes in [3].

2 Preliminary

2.1 Notations

Let $\mathbb{Z}$ denote the ring of integers, $\mathbb{F}_q$ denote the finite field with q elements. Let $\mathbb{F}_q^n$ denote the vector space, where each element is from $\mathbb{F}_q$. Let $n \in \mathbb{Z}$ be a primitive prime, i.e., 2 is a primitive root of n . Then we construct the polynomial ring $\mathcal{R} = \mathbb{F}_2[X]/(X^n - 1)$. Vectors are generally denoted by bold lowercase letters, e.g., $\mathbf{v}$, while matrices are denoted by uppercase letters, e.g., $\mathbf{G}$. Unless otherwise specified, all vectors are treated as row vectors. Given $\mathbf{v} \in \mathbb{F}_2^n$, let $\text{rot}(\mathbf{v})$ denote the circulant matrix generated by $\mathbf{v}$, i.e.,

$$\text{rot}(\mathbf{v}) = \begin{pmatrix} v_0 & v_{n-1} & \cdots & v_1 \\ v_1 & v_0 & \cdots & v_2 \\ \vdots & \vdots & \ddots & \vdots \\ v_{n-1} & v_{n-2} & \cdots & v_0 \end{pmatrix} \in \mathbb{F}_2^{n \times n}.$$

Since there is a natural one-to-one correspondence between the elements and operations in $\mathbb{F}_2^n$ and the polynomial ring $\mathcal{R}$, we will use vectors in $\mathbb{F}_2^n$ and polynomials in $\mathcal{R}$ interchangeably. Specifically, for $\mathbf{v} = (v_0, v_1, \dots, v_{n-1}) \in \mathbb{F}_2^n$, the corresponding element $\mathbf{v} = v_0 + v_1X + \cdots + v_{n-1}X^{n-1} \in \mathcal{R}$. The product of $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v} \in \mathcal{R}$ is $\mathbf{w} = \mathbf{u}\mathbf{v}$ with

$$w_k = \sum_{i+j \equiv k \pmod n} u_i v_j, \quad \forall k \in \{0, 1, \dots, n-1\},$$

which can be expressed as the product of $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v} \in \mathbb{F}_2^n$ with the operator $\text{rot}(\cdot)$ as:

$$\mathbf{u} \cdot \mathbf{v} = \mathbf{u} \times \text{rot}(\mathbf{v})^\top = (\text{rot}(\mathbf{u}) \times \mathbf{v}^\top)^\top = \mathbf{v} \times \text{rot}(\mathbf{u})^\top = \mathbf{v} \cdot \mathbf{u}.$$

Let $w_H(\mathbf{v})$ be the Hamming weight of the vector $\mathbf{v}$, i.e., the number of nonzero positions of $\mathbf{v}$. Let $\mathcal{R}_w := \{\mathbf{v} \in \mathcal{R} | w_H(\mathbf{v}) = w\}$. For $\mathbf{v} = (v_0, \dots, v_{n-1}) \in \mathbb{F}_q^n$, we define $\text{Truncate}(\mathbf{v}, l) := (v_0, \dots, v_{l-1})$ as the function that truncate the vector $\mathbf{v}$ and only keep the l least-significant positions.

2.2 Coding Theory

Definition 1 (Linear Code). A q -ary linear code $\mathcal{C}$ is a linear subspace of $\mathbb{F}_q^n$. If $\mathcal{C}$ has dimension k , it is called an $[n, k]$ or $[n, k]_q$ code. The code $\mathcal{C}$ can be equivalently described in the following ways:

- (i) $\mathcal{C} = \{\mathbf{m}\mathbf{G} \mid \mathbf{m} \in \mathbb{F}_q^k\}$, where $\mathbf{G} \in \mathbb{F}_q^{k \times n}$ is called a generator matrix.
- (ii) $\mathcal{C} = \{\mathbf{c} \in \mathbb{F}_q^n \mid \mathbf{H}\mathbf{c} = \mathbf{0}\}$, where $\mathbf{H} \in \mathbb{F}_q^{(n-k) \times n}$ is called a parity check matrix.

Definition 2 (Minimum Distance). *The minimum distance of a code $\mathcal{C}$ is*

$$\min\{d(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y}) \mid \mathbf{x} \in \mathcal{C}, \mathbf{y} \in \mathcal{C}, \mathbf{x} \neq \mathbf{y}\}$$

If the minimum distance of $\mathcal{C}$ is d , then we also describe it as a $[n, k, d]$ code.

Definition 3 (Perfect Code). *A code $\mathcal{C} \subseteq \mathbb{F}_q^n$ is called a perfect code if its covering radius R is equal to its error-correcting capability $t = \lfloor \frac{d-1}{2} \rfloor$, i.e., the Hamming balls of radius t centered at codewords of $\mathcal{C}$ form a partition of $\mathbb{F}_q^n$.*

There are three kinds of perfect binary codes: Hamming codes, one Golay code, and trivial codes.

Definition 4 (Hamming Codes). *A Hamming code over $\mathbb{F}_2$ has parameters $[2^m - 1, 2^m - m - 1, 3]_2$ for any integer $m \geq 2$.*

Definition 5 (Binary Golay Code). *A binary Golay code has parameters $[23, 12, 7]_2$.*

Definition 6 (Concatenated Codes). *A concatenated code over $\mathbb{F}_2$ consists of an external code $\mathcal{C}_e$ with parameters $[n_e, k_e, d_e]$ over $\mathbb{F}_q$ and an internal code $\mathcal{C}_i$ with parameters $[n_i, k_i, d_i]$ over $\mathbb{F}_2$, where $q = 2^{k_i}$. The resulting concatenated code is a binary code with parameters $[N = n_e n_i, K = k_e k_i, D \geq d_e d_i]$.*

2.3 Security Definitions

We introduce the security notions IND-CPA and IND-CCA2 for PKE and KEM, respectively. The corresponding security games and advantages are defined below.

Definition 7. *Let $\text{PKE} = (\text{Keygen}, \text{Encrypt}, \text{Decrypt})$ be a public-key encryption scheme, the IND-CPA advantage of a probabilistic polynomial time adversary $\mathcal{A} = (\mathcal{A}_{\text{CHOOSE}}, \mathcal{A}_{\text{GUESS}})$ is defined as:*

$$\text{Adv}_{\text{PKE}}^{\text{IND-CPA}}(\mathcal{A}) = |\Pr[\text{PKE.IND-CPA}(\mathcal{A}) = 1] - \frac{1}{2}|,$$

where the IND-CPA game is defined as follows.

(IND-CPA Game)

1. $(\mathbf{ek}, \mathbf{dk}) \leftarrow \text{Keygen}()$
2. $(\mathbf{m}_0, \mathbf{m}_1) \leftarrow \mathcal{A}_{\text{CHOOSE}}(\mathbf{ek})$
3. $b \xleftarrow{\$} \{0, 1\}, \theta \xleftarrow{\$} \mathcal{B}^{|\theta|}$
4. $\mathbf{c}_{\text{PKE}} \leftarrow \text{Encrypt}(\mathbf{ek}, \mathbf{m}_b, \theta)$
5. $b' \leftarrow \mathcal{A}_{\text{GUESS}}(\mathbf{ek}, \mathbf{c}_{\text{PKE}})$
6. return $(b = b')$

Definition 8. Let $\text{KEM} = (\text{Keygen}, \text{Encaps}, \text{Decaps})$ be a key encapsulation mechanism, the IND-CCA2 advantage of a probabilistic polynomial time adversary $\mathcal{A} = \mathcal{A}_{\text{GUESS}}$ with access to a decapsulation oracle Decaps is defined as:

$$\text{Adv}_{\text{KEM}}^{\text{IND-CCA2}}(\mathcal{A}) = |\Pr[\text{KEM.IND-CCA2}(\mathcal{A}) = 1] - \frac{1}{2}|,$$

where the IND-CCA2 game is defined as follows.

(IND-CCA2 Game)

1. $(\text{ek}, \text{dk}) \leftarrow \text{Keygen}()$
2. $b \xleftarrow{\$} \{0, 1\}$
3. $(\mathbf{K}_0, \mathbf{c}_{\text{KEM}}) \leftarrow \text{Encaps}(\text{ek})$
4. $\mathbf{K}_1 \xleftarrow{\$} \mathcal{B}^{|\mathbf{K}_1|}$
5. $b' \leftarrow \mathcal{A}_{\text{GUESS}}^{\text{DECAPS}(\cdot)}(\mathbf{K}_b, \mathbf{c}_{\text{KEM}})$ where the adversary is not allowed to query $\mathbf{c}_{\text{KEM}}$ to the decapsulation oracle
6. return $(b = b')$

3 Compression with Covering Codes

3.1 Motivation

In [3], the authors propose a ciphertext compression technique based on a quantization code with a direct product structure, focusing on Hamming and Golay codes. From the perspective of error-correcting codes, in order to decode an arbitrary vector, the Hamming balls centered at the codewords with radius equal to the error-correcting capability must cover the entire space exactly. Codes with this property are known as perfect codes in Definition 3. While effective, the class of non-trivial binary linear perfect codes is extremely limited, consisting only of Hamming codes and the binary Golay code. This restriction significantly narrows the design space if one relies solely on traditional error-correcting codes for compression.

In contrast, when viewed from a covering perspective, the requirements are relaxed: decoding regions may overlap, which dramatically increases the range of admissible constructions. A wide variety of covering codes with diverse parameters has been proposed in [5]. Although these codes generally lose the perfect packing property, the additional flexibility in their parameters can be leveraged to better balance the trade-off between compression efficiency and error tolerance. This observation motivates the exploration of more general covering codes for ciphertext compression, beyond the classical perfect codes used in [3].

3.2 Covering Codes

Having motivated the use of covering codes, we now introduce the formal definition in Definition 9.

Definition 9 (Covering Code). A linear $[n, k]_q$ code $\mathcal{C}$ has covering radius R if any of the following equivalent conditions holds:

- (i) The value R is the smallest integer such that the space $\mathbb{F}_q^n$ is covered by Hamming balls of radius R centered at the codewords of $\mathcal{C}$.
- (ii) Every vector in $\mathbb{F}_q^{n-k}$ can be expressed as a linear combination of at most R columns of the parity check matrix of $\mathcal{C}$, and R is the smallest value with this property.

The encoding of covering codes is obtained by multiplying the generator matrix. When the covering radius R is small, we can decode any covering codes with the table-based syndrome decoding technique similar in [8].

Algorithm 1 Syndrome Table Decoding

Input: Parity check matrix $\mathbf{H}$, received vector $\mathbf{v}$

Parameter: Covering radius R

Output: Error vector $\mathbf{e}$

```

1: Initialize an empty table  $\mathcal{T}$ 
2: for all  $\mathbf{e} \in \mathbb{F}_2^n$  with  $w_H(\mathbf{e}) \leq R$  do
3:    $\mathbf{s} \leftarrow \mathbf{H}\mathbf{e}^T$ 
4:   if  $\mathbf{s} \notin \mathcal{T}$  or  $w_H(\mathbf{e}) < w_H(\mathcal{T}[\mathbf{s}])$  then
5:      $\mathcal{T}[\mathbf{s}] \leftarrow \mathbf{e}$ 
6:   end if
7: end for
8:  $\mathbf{s}_v \leftarrow \mathbf{H}\mathbf{v}^T$ 
9: return  $\mathcal{T}[\mathbf{s}_v]$ 

```

With the algorithm in [Algorithm 1](#), decoding is guaranteed to succeed when a covering code is employed. Regarding efficiency, the table $\mathcal{T}$ can be precomputed offline in $\sum_{i=0}^R \binom{n}{i}$ operations by enumerating all error vectors of weight at most R . During the online phase, the decoding complexity is dominated by the computation of $\mathbf{H}\mathbf{v}^T$, which requires $O(n(n-k))$ operations.

3.3 Compression

We then analyze how to compress the ciphertext with covering codes. Given a vector $\mathbf{v} \in \mathbb{F}_2^{l_1}$ and a covering code $\mathcal{C}_{cover}$ with parameter $[n_2, k_2]$, we first divide $\mathbf{v}$ into $q = \lfloor l_1/n_2 \rfloor$ even blocks and $l_1 - qn_2$ redundancy bits, i.e., $\mathbf{v} = (\mathbf{v}_1 || \mathbf{v}_2)$ where $\mathbf{v}_1 = (\mathbf{v}_1^{(0)}, \dots, \mathbf{v}_1^{(q-1)})$ and $\mathbf{v}_1^{(i)} \in \mathbb{F}_2^{n_2}$. Then, in each block, we calculate $\mathbf{m}^{(i)} = \mathcal{C}_{cover}.Decode(\mathbf{v}_1^{(i)})$. Finally, we concatenate the message $\tilde{\mathbf{m}} = (\mathbf{m}^{(0)}, \dots, \mathbf{m}^{(q-1)})$. The compressed vector is the tuple of $(\tilde{\mathbf{m}}, \mathbf{v}_2)$.

The extra error rate caused by the compression technique is calculated in [Theorem 1](#).

Theorem 1. Let $\mathcal{C}_2$ be the direct product of covering code $\mathcal{C}_{cover}$ with parameters $[n_2, k_2]_2$ and covering radius R_2 . For a random vector $\mathbf{v}_1$, let $\tilde{\mathbf{m}} = \mathcal{C}_2.\text{Decode}(\mathbf{v}_1)$ and $\tilde{\mathbf{e}} = (\mathbf{v}_1 - \tilde{\mathbf{m}}\mathbf{G}_2) \bmod{2^{n-l_2}}$. Then the probability $\Pr[\tilde{e}_i = 1] \leq \frac{R_2}{n_2}$ for all $0 \leq i < l_2$. Thus, the expected Hamming weight of $\tilde{\mathbf{e}}$ is upper bounded by $\frac{R_2 l_2}{n_2}$, and hence the average probability that a coordinate of $\tilde{\mathbf{e}}$ equals 1 is upper bounded by $\frac{l_2 \cdot R_2}{n \cdot n_2}$.

Proof. We first divide $\mathbf{v}_1$ into q blocks with even length as $\mathbf{v}_1 = (\mathbf{v}_1^{(0)} \parallel \dots \parallel \mathbf{v}_1^{(q-1)})$, where $q = \frac{l_2}{n_2}$ is the number of blocks. Similarly, we divide the first l_2 elements of $\tilde{\mathbf{e}}$ as $(\tilde{\mathbf{e}}^{(0)}, \dots, \tilde{\mathbf{e}}^{(q-1)})$. Then we consider the decoding procedure of the covering code $\mathcal{C}_{cover}$ in $\mathbf{v}_1^{(j)}$, where $0 \leq j < q$. With the radius equal to R_2 , we have $\Pr[\tilde{e}_i^{(j)} = 1] \leq R_2/n_2$ for all $0 \leq i < n_1, 0 \leq j < q$. Consequently, the expected Hamming weight of $\tilde{\mathbf{e}}$ is upper bounded by $l_2 R_2/n_2$, and the average probability that a coordinate of $\tilde{\mathbf{e}}$ equals 1 is upper bounded by $\frac{l_2 \cdot R_2}{n \cdot n_2}$. $\square$

3.4 Instantiation

To demonstrate the practical use of covering codes for ciphertext compression, we consider a concrete instantiation. Among the candidate codes in [5], we select the KR code, which provides an efficient balance between compression and error tolerance.

Definition 10 (Kaikkonen-Rosendahl Code). Let $\mathcal{C}_{KR}$ be the binary $[51, 41]_2$ code with the parity check matrix $\mathbf{H}_{KR} = [\mathbf{I}_{10} \mathbf{M}_{KR}]$, where $\mathbf{M}_{KR}$ is the 10×41 binary matrix with the following columns in hexadecimal notation:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbf{M}_{KR} = [& 1B6, 193, 1CC, 187, 1F6, F7, 16E, 140, 3C, 296, 22F, 303, 381, 365, \\ & 11D, 1A3, 274, 2F2, 254, 56, F, 41, 357, 208, 34, 329, 28D, 31D, 3D5, \\ & 129, 3D7, B7, 3EC, 2E2, 23C, AD, 34E, 155, 2E6, 371, D4] \end{aligned} \quad (1)$$

It is proven in [11] that $\mathcal{C}_{KR}$ is a $[51, 41]_2$ code with covering radius 2. In our scheme, we choose $\mathcal{C}_2$ as the direct product of $\mathcal{C}_{KR}$. The direct product code $\mathcal{C}_2$ is decoded in a block-wise manner, where the decoding of $\mathcal{C}_{KR}$ follows the procedure described in Algorithm 1.

4 Specifications

4.1 Overview of HARE-PKE

Before presenting the formal definition of HARE-PKE, we first describe the main idea and the procedures of the scheme at a high level. Compared to the original HQC scheme [16], in addition to the distance-informed erasure decoding as described in Section 1, we introduce asymmetric error weights for $\mathbf{r}_1, \mathbf{r}_2$, and $\mathbf{e}$ and accordingly adapt the underlying security assumptions. This design is inspired by the use of asymmetric error distributions in lattice-based constructions [22]. Moreover, we incorporate the ciphertext compression technique proposed in [3].

- **Keygen()**: samples $\mathbf{h} \xleftarrow{\$} \mathcal{R}$, $\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y} \xleftarrow{\$} \mathcal{R}_w \times \mathcal{R}_w$, sets $\mathbf{sk} = (\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y})$ and $\mathbf{pk} = (\mathbf{h}, \mathbf{s} = \mathbf{x} + \mathbf{h} \cdot \mathbf{y})$, and returns $(\mathbf{pk}, \mathbf{sk})$
- **Encrypt**($\mathbf{pk}, \mathbf{m}$): generates $\mathbf{e} \xleftarrow{\$} \mathcal{R}_{w_e}$, $\mathbf{r} = (\mathbf{r}_1, \mathbf{r}_2) \xleftarrow{\$} \mathcal{R}_{w_r} \times \mathcal{R}_{w_r}$, sets $\mathbf{u} = \mathbf{r}_1 + \mathbf{h} \cdot \mathbf{r}_2$ and $\mathbf{v} = \text{Truncate}(\mathbf{mG}_1 + \mathbf{s} \cdot \mathbf{r}_2 + \mathbf{e}, l_1)$, splits $\mathbf{v}_1 = \mathbf{v}[0, l_2 - 1]$ and $\mathbf{v}_2 = \mathbf{v}[l_2, l_1]$, decodes $\tilde{\mathbf{m}} = \mathcal{C}_2.\text{Decode}(\mathbf{v}_1)$, returns $\mathbf{c} = (\mathbf{u}, \tilde{\mathbf{m}}, \mathbf{v}_2)$
- **Decrypt**($\mathbf{sk}, \mathbf{c}$): recovers $\tilde{\mathbf{v}} = (\tilde{\mathbf{m}}\mathbf{G}_2 \| \mathbf{v}_2)$, returns $\mathcal{C}_1.\text{Decode}(\tilde{\mathbf{v}} - \text{Truncate}(\mathbf{u} \cdot \mathbf{y}, l_1))$

The matrices $\mathbf{G}_1$ and $\mathbf{G}_2$ denote the generator matrices of the codes $\mathcal{C}_1$ and $\mathcal{C}_2$, respectively. In our scheme, we choose concatenated Reed-Muller codes of length n_2 and Reed-Solomon codes of length n_1 to construct $\mathcal{C}_1$, and direct product of $\mathcal{C}_{KR}$ for $\mathcal{C}_2$. The function $\text{Truncate}(\mathbf{v}, l)$ splits the vector $\mathbf{v}$ into two segments and keeps only the first segment of length l .

Correctness. Let $\tilde{\mathbf{e}} = \tilde{\mathbf{m}}\mathbf{G}_2 - \mathbf{v}_1$ denote the noise introduced in $\mathcal{C}_2$. For simplicity, we omit truncation and assume all vectors have matching lengths. The decryption can then be written as

$$\begin{aligned}
\tilde{\mathbf{v}} - \mathbf{u}\mathbf{y} &= (\tilde{\mathbf{m}}\mathbf{G}_2 \| \mathbf{v}_2) - \mathbf{u}\mathbf{y} \\
&= (\mathbf{v}_1 + \tilde{\mathbf{e}} \| \mathbf{v}_2) - \mathbf{u}\mathbf{y} \\
&= \mathbf{v} + \tilde{\mathbf{e}} - \mathbf{u}\mathbf{y} \\
&= \mathbf{mG}_1 + \mathbf{s}\mathbf{r}_2 + \mathbf{e} + \tilde{\mathbf{e}} - (\mathbf{r}_1 + \mathbf{h}\mathbf{r}_2)\mathbf{y} \\
&= \mathbf{mG}_1 + \mathbf{x}\mathbf{r}_2 - \mathbf{y}\mathbf{r}_1 + \mathbf{e} + \tilde{\mathbf{e}}.
\end{aligned}$$

Since $\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y}, \mathbf{r}_1, \mathbf{r}_2, \mathbf{e}, \tilde{\mathbf{e}}$ all have low Hamming weight, the equivalent error in $\mathcal{C}_1$ is $\mathbf{x}\mathbf{r}_2 - \mathbf{y}\mathbf{r}_1 + \mathbf{e} + \tilde{\mathbf{e}}$ with relatively low weight. Decryption succeeds if and only if this equivalent error is within the error-correcting capability of $\mathcal{C}_1$.

4.2 Concatenated Reed-Muller and Reed-Solomon Codes

In this section, we introduce how we construct $\mathcal{C}_1$ with concatenated RM and RS codes and our erasure decoding algorithm.

4.2.1 Duplicated Reed-Muller Codes

We propose a modified decoding algorithm, $\text{Decode}'()$, for duplicated Reed-Muller codes, as described in [Algorithm 2](#). The algorithm outputs either a message $\mathbf{m}$ or an erasure symbol $\perp$, depending on the confidence of the decoding result.

The main modification compared to the classical decoding in [\[16\]](#) is as follows. Instead of directly decoding to the nearest codeword, we first identify the two codewords with the smallest Hamming distances to the received vector. If the difference between these two distances exceeds a threshold α , the vector is decoded to the nearest codeword. Otherwise, the decoder outputs an erasure symbol $\perp$, indicating insufficient confidence. This approach reduces the probability of incorrect decoding by explicitly marking uncertain positions as erasures, which can then be handled in the subsequent Reed-Solomon decoding stage.

For context, a Reed-Muller code $\text{RM}(r, m)$ with positive integer m and $0 \leq r \leq m$ has parameters $[n, k, d_{\min}] = [2^m, \sum_{i=0}^r \binom{m}{i}, 2^{m-r}]$, and duplicated RM codes are constructed by repeating each codeword multiple times [14]. Encoding is performed by multiplying the message with the generator matrix.

Algorithm 2 Decode' for RM

Input: Vector $\mathbf{x}$ to be corrected

Parameter: RM code of $[n_i, k_i, d_i]$ over $\mathbb{F}_2$ with generation matrix $\mathbf{G}$, threshold α

Output: Message $\mathbf{m}$ or $\perp$

```

1:  $\mathbf{m}_1, \mathbf{m}_2 \leftarrow \mathbf{0}, \mathbf{0}$ 
2: Construct  $\mathcal{D} \leftarrow \{(d, \mathbf{m}) | d = w_H(\mathbf{m}\mathbf{G} - \mathbf{x})\}$  with Hadamard transform
3: Sort  $\mathcal{D}$  in ascending order of  $d$ 
4:  $(d_1, \mathbf{m}_1), (d_2, \mathbf{m}_2)$  be the first two elements in  $\mathcal{D}$ 
5: if  $d_2 - d_1 > \alpha$  then
6:   return  $\mathbf{m}_1$ 
7: else
8:   return  $\perp$ 
9: end if

```

4.2.2 Reed-Solomon codes

When performing the decoding function of shortened Reed-Solomon codes, we employ a modified decoding procedure that tolerates erasures. We summarize the encoding and decoding procedures of the shortened Reed-Solomon code as follows.

Let p be a prime number and q be a power of p . A Reed-Solomon code $\text{RS}[n, k, d_{\min}]$ with symbols in $\mathbb{F}_q$ has block length $n = q - 1$, dimension k , and minimum distance $d_{\min}$. A codeword with g errors and h erasures can be decoded correctly if $2g + h \leq n - k$.

Shortened Reed-Solomon codes. For the three HARE parameter sets, we construct shortened Reed-Solomon codes from classical RS codes with $k = 16, 24$, and 32. The resulting code parameters are summarized in Table 1. Note that shortening a Reed-Solomon code does not affect its error-correcting capacity.

Code	n	k	$d_{\min}$
RS-S1	40	16	25
RS-S3	50	24	27
RS-S5	70	32	39

Table 1: The parameter choices for shortened RS codes in HARE.

Constructing and encoding shortened Reed-Solomon codes. For HARE, we work over $\mathbb{F}_{2^m}$ with $m = 8$. To construct this field, we use the primitive polynomial $1 + \alpha^2 + \alpha^3 + \alpha^4 + \alpha^8$ of degree 8 with a primitive element α . The generator polynomials of RS-S1, RS-S3, and RS-S5 can be computed as $g(x) = \prod_{i=1}^{n-k} (x + \alpha^i)$.

The encoding of shortened Reed-Solomon code is the same as that of classical RS code. We denote the message $u = (u_0, \dots, u_{k-1})$ by the polynomial $u(x) = u_0 + \dots + u_{k-1}x^{k-1}$. Following [12], the codeword polynomial $c(x)$ is given by $c(x) = b(x) + x^{n-k}u(x)$, where $b(x)$ is the remainder of the division of the polynomial $x^{n-k}u(x)$ by $g(x)$.

Decoding shortened Reed-Solomon codes. In the decoding procedure, we should decode Reed-Solomon codes with both errors and erasures. We denote the received polynomial $r(x) = r_0 + \dots + r_{n-1}x^{n-1}$. Suppose there are g errors at positions $j_1, \dots, j_g$ and h erasures at positions $l_1, \dots, l_h$, then the error polynomial and the erasure polynomial can be denoted as $e(x) = e_{j_1}x^{j_1} + \dots + e_{j_g}x^{j_g}$ and $w(x) = w_{l_1}x^{l_1} + \dots + w_{l_h}x^{l_h}$. For simplicity, we define location numbers $\beta_i = \alpha^{j_i}$ and $\eta_t = \alpha^{l_t}$ to indicate the locations of errors and erasures. The received polynomial can be represented by $r(x) = v(x) + e(x) + w(x)$, where $v(x)$ is the original codeword.

To describe the locations of errors and erasures, we define the error locator polynomial $\sigma(x)$, the erasure locator polynomial $\gamma(x)$ and the total locator polynomial $\Lambda(x)$ as follows.

$$\begin{aligned}\sigma(x) &= \prod_{i=1}^g (1 + \beta_i x) = 1 + \sigma_1 x + \dots + \sigma_g x^g, \\ \gamma(x) &= \prod_{t=1}^h (1 + \eta_t x) = 1 + \gamma_1 x + \dots + \gamma_h x^h, \\ \Lambda(x) &= \sigma(x)\gamma(x)\end{aligned}$$

We then define the syndromes $S_1, \dots, S_{n-k}$ as $S_i = r(\alpha^i)$. We have $S_i = e(\alpha^i) + w(\alpha^i)$ since $v(\alpha^i) = 0$. With the erasure locations known, we obtain $n - k$ equations with $2g + h$ unknowns including e_{j_i}, β_i and w_{l_t} .

$$\begin{cases} S_1 = \sum_{i=1}^g e_{j_i} \beta_i + \sum_{t=1}^h w_{l_t} \eta_t \\ S_2 = \sum_{i=1}^g e_{j_i} \beta_i^2 + \sum_{t=1}^h w_{l_t} \eta_t^2 \\ \dots \\ S_{n-k} = \sum_{i=1}^g e_{j_i} \beta_i^{n-k} + \sum_{t=1}^h w_{l_t} \eta_t^{n-k} \end{cases} \quad (2)$$

Our goal is to solve the $2g + h$ unknowns in (2). According to [12], the decoding procedure can be summarized in the following steps:

1. Compute the syndromes $S_1, \dots, S_{n-k}$ by evaluating $r(\alpha^i)$ for each i .
2. Compute the modified syndrome polynomial $T(x) = S(x)\gamma(x) \bmod x^{n-k}$ **with the erasures considered**, where $S(x) = 1 + S_1 x + \dots + S_{n-k} x^{n-k}$

is the syndrome polynomial. Then use Berlekamp-Massey (BM) to compute the error locator polynomial $\sigma(x)$.

3. Find the error location numbers by calculating the roots of the polynomial $\sigma(x)$ and returning their inverses. This step can be implemented through an additive Fast Fourier Transform algorithm.
4. Compute the polynomial $Z(x) = S(x)\Lambda(x) \bmod x^{n-k}$. This polynomial is used to determine the error and erasure values.
5. Compute the error and erasure values at position s by

$$\varepsilon_s = \frac{\alpha^s Z(\alpha^{-s})}{Z'(\alpha^{-s})} \quad (3)$$

6. Correct errors and restore erasures, i.e., $v(x) = r(x) + e(x) + w(x)$.

The main modification of the decoding procedure with erasures from the classical one in [16] is step 2. In order to take the erasure positions into consideration when processing the syndromes, we calculate the modified syndrome polynomial $T(x) = S(x)\gamma(x) \bmod x^{n-k} = 1 + T_1x + \dots + T_{n-k-1}x^{n-k-1}$, where $T_1, \dots, T_{n-k-1}$ are called the modified syndromes. Following [12], the modified syndromes and the coefficients $\sigma_1, \dots, \sigma_g$ satisfy

$$T_i + \sigma_1 T_{i-1} + \dots + \sigma_g T_{i-g} = 0, \quad i = g+1, g+2, \dots, n-k-h, \quad (4)$$

which is a linear feedback shift register with sequence $T_1, \dots, T_{n-k-h}$ and coefficients $\sigma_1, \dots, \sigma_g$, thus we can compute the coefficients by BM algorithm [12]. Notice that the relation holds only for the first $n-k-h$ modified syndromes, so the BM procedure contains only $n-k-h$ loops of iteration rather than $n-k$.

After retrieving the coefficients of $\sigma(x)$, we can compute all the error positions by finding the inverses of the roots of $\sigma(x)$. From then on, errors and erasures can be treated equivalently, since all the positions are clear. The following steps are the same as those in [16].

4.3 Auxiliary Primitives

Prior to discussing the instantiation of HARE-PKE and HARE-KEM, we introduce several auxiliary primitives used for pseudorandom byte generation, hashing, and vector sampling.

- **Extendable Output Function:** XOF generates a pseudorandom byte string of arbitrary length from a given short seed.
- **Hash Functions:** G, H, I, J denote cryptographic hash functions.
- **Vector Sampling:** SampleVec and SampleFixedWeightVec are employed to sample random vectors from the spaces $\mathcal{R}$ and $\mathcal{R}_w$, respectively.

We omit a detailed discussion of these primitives here. For concrete instantiations and implementation details, one can refer to Section 3 of [16].

4.4 PKE

We now describe the HARE-PKE scheme. The formal procedures are given in [Algorithm 3](#), [Algorithm 4](#), and [Algorithm 5](#).

Algorithm 3 PKE.Keygen()

Input: Seed seed_{PKE}

Output: Encryption key ek_{PKE} and decryption key dk_{PKE}

- 1: $\text{seed}_{\text{PKE.dk}}, \text{seed}_{\text{PKE.ek}} \leftarrow \text{I}(\text{seed}_{\text{PKE}})$
 - 2: $\text{ctx}_{\text{PKE.dk}} \leftarrow \text{XOF.Init}(\text{seed}_{\text{PKE.dk}})$
 - 3: $\text{ctx}_{\text{PKE.ek}} \leftarrow \text{XOF.Init}(\text{seed}_{\text{PKE.ek}})$
 - 4: $\text{ctx}_{\text{PKE.dk}}, \mathbf{y} \leftarrow \text{SampleFixedWeightVec}(\text{ctx}_{\text{PKE.dk}}, \mathcal{R}_w)$
 - 5: $\text{ctx}_{\text{PKE.dk}}, \mathbf{x} \leftarrow \text{SampleFixedWeightVec}(\text{ctx}_{\text{PKE.dk}}, \mathcal{R}_w)$
 - 6: $\text{dk}_{\text{PKE}} \leftarrow \text{seed}_{\text{PKE.dk}}$
 - 7: $\text{ctx}_{\text{PKE.ek}}, \mathbf{h} \leftarrow \text{SampleVec}(\text{ctx}_{\text{PKE.ek}}, \mathcal{R})$
 - 8: $\mathbf{s} \leftarrow \mathbf{x} + \mathbf{h} \cdot \mathbf{y}$
 - 9: $\text{ek}_{\text{PKE}} \leftarrow (\text{seed}_{\text{PKE.ek}}, \mathbf{s})$
 - 10: **return** $(\text{ek}_{\text{PKE}}, \text{dk}_{\text{PKE}})$
-

Algorithm 4 PKE.Encrypt()

Input: Encryption key ek_{PKE} , message $\mathbf{m}$ and randomness θ

Output: Ciphertext $\mathbf{c}$

- 1: $\text{seed}_{\text{PKE.ek}} \leftarrow \text{ek}_{\text{PKE}}[0 : |\text{seed}| - 1]$
 - 2: $\text{ctx}_{\text{PKE.ek}} \leftarrow \text{XOF.Init}(\text{seed}_{\text{PKE.ek}})$
 - 3: $\text{ctx}_{\text{PKE.ek}}, \mathbf{h} \leftarrow \text{SampleVec}(\text{ctx}_{\text{PKE.ek}}, \mathcal{R})$
 - 4: $\mathbf{s} \leftarrow \text{ek}_{\text{PKE}}[|\text{seed}| : |\text{seed}| + |\mathbf{s}| - 1]$
 - 5: $\text{ctx}_{\theta} \leftarrow \text{XOF.Init}(\theta)$
 - 6: $\mathbf{e} \leftarrow \text{SampleFixedWeightVec}(\text{ctx}_{\theta}, \mathcal{R}_{w_e})$
 - 7: $\mathbf{r}_1 \leftarrow \text{SampleFixedWeightVec}(\text{ctx}_{\theta}, \mathcal{R}_{w_r})$
 - 8: $\mathbf{r}_2 \leftarrow \text{SampleFixedWeightVec}(\text{ctx}_{\theta}, \mathcal{R}_{w_r})$
 - 9: $\mathbf{u} \leftarrow \mathbf{r}_1 + \mathbf{h} \cdot \mathbf{r}_2$
 - 10: $\mathbf{v} \leftarrow \mathbf{mG}_1 + \text{Truncate}(\mathbf{s} \cdot \mathbf{r}_2 + \mathbf{e}, l_1)$
 - 11: $\mathbf{v}_1 \leftarrow \mathbf{v}[0, l_2 - 1]$
 - 12: $\mathbf{v}_2 \leftarrow \mathbf{v}[l_2, l_1 - 1]$
 - 13: $\tilde{\mathbf{m}} \leftarrow \mathcal{C}_2.\text{Decode}(\mathbf{v}_1)$
 - 14: $\mathbf{c} \leftarrow (\mathbf{u}, \tilde{\mathbf{m}}, \mathbf{v}_2)$
 - 15: **return** $\mathbf{c}$
-

4.5 KEM

We then construct HARE-KEM from HARE-PKE using the Fujisaki-Okamoto transformation [\[6\]](#) and the HHK framework with implicit rejection [\[7\]](#). The for-

Algorithm 5 PKE.Decrypt()

Input: Decryption key $\mathbf{dk}_{\text{PKE}}$ and ciphertext $\mathbf{c}$

Output: Message $\mathbf{m}$

- 1: $\text{ctx}_{\text{PKE.dk}} \leftarrow \text{XOF.Init}(\mathbf{dk}_{\text{PKE}})$
 - 2: $\text{ctx}_{\text{PKE.dk}}, \mathbf{y} \leftarrow \text{SampleFixedWeightVec}(\text{ctx}_{\text{PKE.dk}}, \mathcal{R}_w)$
 - 3: $\mathbf{u} \leftarrow \mathbf{c}[0 : |\mathbf{u}|]$
 - 4: $\tilde{\mathbf{m}} \leftarrow \mathbf{c}[|\mathbf{u}| : |\mathbf{u}| + |\tilde{\mathbf{m}}| - 1]$
 - 5: $\mathbf{v}_2 \leftarrow \mathbf{c}[|\mathbf{u}| + |\tilde{\mathbf{m}}| : |\mathbf{c}| - 1]$
 - 6: $\tilde{\mathbf{v}} \leftarrow (\tilde{\mathbf{m}}\mathbf{G}_2, \mathbf{v}_2)$
 - 7: $\mathbf{m} \leftarrow \mathcal{C}_1.\text{Decode}(\tilde{\mathbf{v}} - \text{Truncate}(\mathbf{u}\mathbf{y}, l_1))$
 - 8: **return** $\mathbf{m}$
-

mal procedures are specified in [Algorithm 6](#), [Algorithm 7](#), and [Algorithm 8](#).

Algorithm 6 HARE-KEM.Keygen()

Input: None

Output: Encapsulation key $\mathbf{ek}_{\text{KEM}}$ and decapsulation key $\mathbf{dk}_{\text{KEM}}$

- 1: $\text{seed}_{\text{KEM}} \xleftarrow{\$} \mathcal{B}^{|\text{seed}|}$
 - 2: $\text{ctx}_{\text{KEM}} \leftarrow \text{XOF.Init}(\text{seed}_{\text{KEM}})$
 - 3: $(\text{ctx}_{\text{KEM}}, \text{seed}_{\text{PKE}}) \leftarrow \text{XOF.GetBytes}(\text{ctx}_{\text{KEM}}, |\text{seed}|)$
 - 4: $(\text{ctx}_{\text{KEM}}, \sigma) \leftarrow \text{XOF.GetBytes}(\text{ctx}_{\text{KEM}}, |\mathbf{K}|)$
 - 5: $(\mathbf{ek}_{\text{PKE}}, \mathbf{dk}_{\text{PKE}}) \leftarrow \text{HARE-PKE.Keygen}(\text{seed}_{\text{PKE}})$
 - 6: $\mathbf{ek}_{\text{KEM}} \leftarrow \mathbf{ek}_{\text{PKE}}$
 - 7: $\mathbf{dk}_{\text{KEM}} \leftarrow (\mathbf{ek}_{\text{KEM}}, \mathbf{dk}_{\text{PKE}}, \sigma, \text{seed}_{\text{KEM}})$
 - 8: **return** $(\mathbf{ek}_{\text{KEM}}, \mathbf{dk}_{\text{KEM}})$
-

5 Parameters Choices

5.1 Parameter Sets

We design the parameter choices in Table 2, which includes the classic security, quant security, length of the quasi-cyclic code n and dimension of the concatenated code k . The parameters w, w_r and w_e represent the Hamming weight of vectors $(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y})$, $(\mathbf{r}_1, \mathbf{r}_2)$ and $\mathbf{e}$, respectively. For code choices, n_1 denotes the length of RS code, n_2 denotes the length of RM code and α denotes the threshold in the decoding procedure. We upper bound the decryption failure rate (DFR) for each parameter set.

5.2 Ciphertext and key sizes

The encapsulation key $\mathbf{ek}_{\text{KEM}}$ has size $|\mathbf{ek}_{\text{KEM}}| = |\text{seed}| + \lceil n/8 \rceil$ while the decapsulation key $\mathbf{dk}_{\text{KEM}}$ has size $|\mathbf{dk}_{\text{KEM}}| = |\text{seed}|$ with the compressed format used.

Algorithm 7 HARE-KEM.Encaps($\mathbf{ek}_{\text{KEM}}$)

Input: Encapsulation key $\mathbf{ek}_{\text{KEM}}$

Output: Shared secret key $\mathbf{K}$ and ciphertext $\mathbf{c}_{\text{KEM}}$

- 1: $\mathbf{m} \xleftarrow{\$} \mathcal{B}^{|\mathbf{K}|}$
 - 2: $\mathbf{salt} \xleftarrow{\$} \mathcal{B}^{|\mathbf{salt}|}$
 - 3: $(K, \theta) \leftarrow \text{G}(\text{H}(\mathbf{ek}_{\text{KEM}}) \parallel \mathbf{m} \parallel \mathbf{salt})$
 - 4: $\mathbf{c}_{\text{PKE}} \leftarrow \text{HARE-PKE.Encrypt}(\mathbf{ek}_{\text{KEM}}, \mathbf{m}, \theta)$
 - 5: $\mathbf{c}_{\text{KEM}} \leftarrow (\mathbf{c}_{\text{PKE}}, \mathbf{salt})$
 - 6: **return** $(\mathbf{K}, \mathbf{c}_{\text{KEM}})$
-

Algorithm 8 HARE-KEM.Decaps($\mathbf{dk}_{\text{KEM}}, \mathbf{c}_{\text{KEM}}$)

Input: Decapsulation key $\mathbf{dk}_{\text{KEM}}$ and ciphertext $\mathbf{c}_{\text{KEM}}$

Output: Shared secret key $\mathbf{K}'$

- 1: $\mathbf{ek}_{\text{KEM}} \leftarrow \mathbf{dk}_{\text{KEM}}[0 : |\mathbf{ek}_{\text{KEM}}|]$
 - 2: $\mathbf{dk}_{\text{PKE}} \leftarrow \mathbf{dk}_{\text{KEM}}[|\mathbf{ek}_{\text{KEM}}| : |\mathbf{ek}_{\text{KEM}}| + |\mathbf{dk}_{\text{PKE}}|]$
 - 3: $\sigma \leftarrow \mathbf{dk}_{\text{KEM}}[|\mathbf{ek}_{\text{KEM}}| + |\mathbf{dk}_{\text{PKE}}| : |\mathbf{ek}_{\text{KEM}}| + |\mathbf{dk}_{\text{PKE}}| + |\sigma|]$
 - 4: $\mathbf{c}_{\text{PKE}} \leftarrow \mathbf{c}_{\text{KEM}}[0 : |\mathbf{c}_{\text{PKE}}|]$
 - 5: $\mathbf{salt} \leftarrow \mathbf{c}_{\text{KEM}}[|\mathbf{c}_{\text{PKE}}| : |\mathbf{c}_{\text{PKE}}| + |\mathbf{salt}|]$
 - 6: $\mathbf{m}' \leftarrow \text{HARE-PKE.Decrypt}(\mathbf{dk}_{\text{PKE}}, \mathbf{c}_{\text{PKE}})$
 - 7: $(\mathbf{K}', \theta') \leftarrow \text{G}(\text{H}(\mathbf{ek}_{\text{KEM}}) \parallel \mathbf{m}' \parallel \mathbf{salt})$
 - 8: $\mathbf{c}'_{\text{PKE}} \leftarrow \text{HARE-PKE.Encrypt}(\mathbf{ek}_{\text{KEM}}, \mathbf{m}', \theta')$
 - 9: $\mathbf{c}'_{\text{KEM}} \leftarrow (\mathbf{c}'_{\text{PKE}}, \mathbf{salt})$
 - 10: $\bar{\mathbf{K}} \leftarrow \text{J}(\text{H}(\mathbf{ek}_{\text{KEM}}) \parallel \sigma \parallel \mathbf{c}_{\text{KEM}})$
 - 11: **if** $\mathbf{m}' = \perp$ **or if** $\mathbf{c}'_{\text{KEM}} \neq \mathbf{c}_{\text{KEM}}$ **then**
 - 12: $\mathbf{K}' \leftarrow \bar{\mathbf{K}}$
 - 13: **end if**
 - 14: **return** $\mathbf{K}'$
-

Instance	Classic Security	Quant Security	n	k	$w = w_r$	w_e	n_1	n_2	α	DFR
HARE-1	128	64	16349	128	66	105	42	384	7	$< 2^{-128}$
HARE-3	192	96	33107	192	100	163	51	640	11	$< 2^{-192}$
HARE-5	256	128	52981	256	131	224	82	640	9	$< 2^{-256}$

Table 2: The parameter choices for HARE.

The ciphertext $\mathbf{c}_{\text{KEM}}$ has size $|\mathbf{c}_{\text{KEM}}| = \lceil n/8 \rceil + \lceil (l_1 - l_2 + k_2 \lfloor l_1/n_2 \rfloor)/8 \rceil + |\mathbf{salt}|$ while the shared key $\mathbf{K}$ has size $|\mathbf{K}|$. The seeds, salt and shared key have size $|\mathbf{seed}| = 32$ B, $|\mathbf{salt}| = 16$ B, $|\mathbf{K}| = 32$ B, respectively. The bandwidth represents the sum of $|\mathbf{ek}_{\text{KEM}}|$ and $|\mathbf{c}_{\text{KEM}}|$. The resulting sizes and comparison with HQC scheme are given in Table 3.

Instance	Security	$ \mathbf{ek}_{\text{KEM}} $	$ \mathbf{dk}_{\text{KEM}} $	$ \mathbf{c}_{\text{KEM}} $	$ \mathbf{K} $	bandwidth
HARE-1	NIST-1	2076	32	3681	32	5757
HQC-1		2241		4433		6674
HARE-3	NIST-3	4171	32	7435	32	11606
HQC-3		4514		8978		13492
HARE-5	NIST-5	6655	32	11913	32	18568
HQC-5		7237		14421		21658

Table 3: The keypair $(\mathbf{ek}_{\text{KEM}}, \mathbf{dk}_{\text{KEM}})$, ciphertext $\mathbf{c}_{\text{KEM}}$, shared key $\mathbf{K}$ sizes and bandwidth of HARE-KEM and HQC-KEM. All sizes are expressed in bytes.

6 Decoding Failure Rate Analysis

6.1 Analysis of Error Distribution

We first calculate the probability distribution of each coordinate e'_k of the error vector

$$\mathbf{e}' = \mathbf{x} \cdot \mathbf{r}_2 - \mathbf{r}_1 \cdot \mathbf{y} + \mathbf{e} + \tilde{\mathbf{e}} = (e'_0, \dots, e'_{n-1}),$$

where $\tilde{\mathbf{e}} = (\mathbf{v}_1 - \tilde{\mathbf{m}}\mathbf{G}_2) \bmod 0^{n-l_1}$ is the error generated by compressing $\mathbf{v}_1$ with covering code.

Based on the error distribution of HQC established in Theorem 2 (see [16] for the proof), we propose the error distribution of HARE in Theorem 3.

Theorem 2. *Let $\mathbf{e}^{\text{HQC}} = \mathbf{x} \cdot \mathbf{r}_2 - \mathbf{r}_1 \cdot \mathbf{y} + \mathbf{e}$, the coordinate has distribution*

$$\Pr[e_k^{\text{HQC}} = 1] = 2\tilde{p}(1 - \tilde{p})(1 - \frac{w_e}{n}) + ((1 - \tilde{p})^2 + \tilde{p}^2) \frac{w_e}{n},$$

where

$$\tilde{p} = \frac{1}{\binom{n}{w}\binom{n}{w_r}} \sum_{\substack{1 \leq l \leq \min(w, w_r) \\ l \text{ odd}}} \binom{n}{l} \binom{n-l}{w-l} \binom{n-w}{w_r-l}.$$

Theorem 3. Let $p_{\text{HQC}} = \Pr[e_k^{\text{HQC}} = 1]$ in [Theorem 2](#) and $p_{\text{cover}} = \frac{l_2 \cdot R_2}{n \cdot n_2}$ be the error probability generated by the covering code. Then the error distribution is $\Pr[e'_i = 1] = p_{\text{HQC}}(1 - p_{\text{cover}}) + (1 - p_{\text{HQC}})p_{\text{cover}}$.

According to [\[3\]](#), modeling the dependence between coordinates provides a more accurate estimate of the upper bound on the DFR. In our work, for the sake of simplifying the analysis of erasure decoding, we follow the original HQC model and ignore coordinate dependencies in the subsequent analysis.

6.2 DFR of Reed-Muller Codes

We analyze the upper bound on the probability of a decoding error or an erasure in [Theorem 1](#).

Theorem 1. Let p be the transition probability of the binary symmetric channel and α be the decoding threshold of duplicated $\text{RM}[n, k, d]$. With treating some erasures as errors, we can upper bound P_{error} and P_{erasure} as

$$P_{\text{error}} = \sum_{w=0}^n \min \left[\sum_{2j-d > \alpha} 255 \binom{d}{j} \binom{n-d}{w-j}, \binom{n}{w} \right] p^w (1-p)^{n-w}$$

and

$$P_{\text{erasure}} = \sum_{w=0}^n \min \left[\sum_{-\alpha \leq d-2j \leq \alpha} 255 \binom{d}{j} \binom{n-d}{w-j}, \binom{n}{w} \right] p^w (1-p)^{n-w}$$

Proof. Assume the origin codeword without noise is $\mathbf{c}_0 = \mathbf{0}$ and the noise vector is $\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{c}_0 + \mathbf{e}$. During the decoding procedure of the RM code $\mathcal{C}$, the nearest two codewords of $\mathbf{x}$ are $\mathbf{c}_1$ and $\mathbf{c}_2$. Denote $d_0 = w = w_H(\mathbf{c}_0 - \mathbf{x})$, $d_1 = w_H(\mathbf{c}_1 - \mathbf{x})$ and $d_2 = w_H(\mathbf{c}_2 - \mathbf{x})$, then $d_2 \geq d_1$.

- If $\mathbf{c}_1 = \mathbf{c}_0$ and $d_2 - d_1 \leq \alpha$, the output of decoding procedure is erasure. Let $A_{\mathbf{c}_2}^w$ be the event where $\mathbf{c}_1 = \mathbf{c}_0$ and $d_2 - d_1 \leq \alpha$ with fixed w and nonzero codeword $\mathbf{c}_2$. Let $d' = w_H(\mathbf{c}_2 - \mathbf{c}_0)$, then

$$P(A_{\mathbf{c}_2}^w) = \sum_{0 \leq d' - 2j \leq \alpha} \binom{d'}{j} \binom{n-d'}{w-j} p^w (1-p)^{n-w}.$$

By the union bound applied on all nonzero codewords $\mathbf{c}_2 \in \mathcal{C}$, we obtain the probability upper bounded by:

$$\sum_{w=0}^n \sum_{\mathbf{c}_2 \in \mathcal{C}, \mathbf{c}_2 \neq \mathbf{0}} \sum_{0 \leq d' - 2j \leq \alpha} \binom{d'}{j} \binom{n-d'}{w-j} p^w (1-p)^{n-w}.$$

There are 255 nonzero codewords in a $[128, 8, 64]$ Reed-Muller code, 254 of weight 64 and one of weight 128. The contribution of the weight 128 vector is smaller than the weight 64 vectors, and we can obtain the same conclusion in duplicated RM code. As a result, the upper bound is

$$\sum_{w=0}^n \sum_{0 \leq d-2j \leq \alpha} 255 \binom{d}{j} \binom{n-d}{w-j} p^w (1-p)^{n-w}.$$

- If $\mathbf{c}_1 = \mathbf{c}_0$ and $d_2 - d_1 > \alpha$, the output of decoding procedure is correct.
- If $\mathbf{c}_1 \neq \mathbf{c}_0$ and $w - d_1 \leq \alpha$, we have $d_2 - d_1 \leq w - d_1 \leq \alpha$, the output is erasure. Similar to the first circumstance, we change the range of sum and calculate the upper bound is

$$\sum_{w=0}^n \sum_{-\alpha \leq d-2j < 0} 255 \binom{d}{j} \binom{n-d}{w-j} p^w (1-p)^{n-w}.$$

- If $\mathbf{c}_1 \neq \mathbf{c}_0$ and $w - d_1 > \alpha$, the output is either error or erasure. For the sake of simplicity, we treat the output as error. Since the **error** has worse effect on RS code decoding than **erasure**, the decoding ability is underestimated. Similarly, we estimate the upper bound as:

$$\sum_{w=0}^n \sum_{2j-d > \alpha} 255 \binom{d}{j} \binom{n-d}{w-j} p^w (1-p)^{n-w}.$$

Since the total number of weight- w error patterns is $\binom{n}{w}$, the inner summation cannot exceed this quantity. Thus, we take the minimum between the inner summation and $\binom{n}{w}$ in all cases. This completes the proof. $\square$

Simulation results validating [Theorem 1](#) are provided in [Appendix A](#).

6.3 DFR of Shortened Reed-Solomon Codes

Let g be the number of errors and h be the number of erasures, the decoding succeeds as long as $2g + h \leq n_e - k_e$. Thus we have the estimate of DFR in [Theorem 2](#).

Theorem 2. *Let p_1 be the probability of a position having error, p_2 be the probability of a position with erasure. Then the DFR of the $\text{RS}[n_e, k_e, d_e]$ is,*

$$\text{DFR} = \sum_{2g+h > n_e - k_e} \binom{n_e}{g} \binom{n_e - g}{h} p_1^g p_2^h (1 - p_1 - p_2)^{n_e - g - h}$$

Proof. The RS code could correct all vectors with $2g + h \leq n_e - k_e$ where g is the number of errors and h is the number of erasures. Thus, decoding failure occurs if and only if $2g + h > n_e - k_e$. Let p_1 the probability of error and p_2 be the probability of erasure, the probability of having g errors and h erasures is $\binom{n_e}{g} \binom{n_e - g}{h} p_1^g p_2^h (1 - p_1 - p_2)^{n_e - g - h}$. Finally, the DFR sums all the terms when $2g + h > n_e - k_e$. $\square$

7 Security Analysis

7.1 Unbalanced-Quasi-Cyclic Syndrome Decoding Problem

In this subsection, we arise the concept of unbalanced-quasi-cyclic syndrome decoding problem (UQCSD) and reduce it to the traditional quasi-cyclic syndrome decoding (QCSD) problem. For the sake of simplicity, we denote this problem in solving version while the decision version is easy to adapt.

Definition 11 (s-QCSD Problem). *Given a matrix $\mathbf{H} \in \mathbb{F}_2^{(sn-n) \times sn}$ and a vector $\mathbf{s} \in \mathbb{F}_2^{sn-n}$, the goal is to find a vector $\mathbf{e} \in \mathbb{F}_2^{sn}$ satisfying $\mathbf{H}\mathbf{e} = \mathbf{s}$. Let $\mathbf{e} = (\mathbf{e}_0, \dots, \mathbf{e}_{s-1})$ where $\mathbf{e}_i \in \mathbb{F}_2^n$ and $w_H(\mathbf{e}_i) = w$ for all $0 \leq i < s$. We call this problem as s-QCSD(n, w) problem.*

Definition 12 (UQCSD Problem). *Given a matrix $\mathbf{H} \in \mathbb{F}_2^{2n \times 3n}$ and a vector $\mathbf{s} \in \mathbb{F}_2^{2n}$, the goal is to find a vector $\mathbf{e} \in \mathbb{F}_2^{3n}$ satisfying $\mathbf{H}\mathbf{e} = \mathbf{s}$. Let $\mathbf{e} = (\mathbf{e}_0, \mathbf{e}_1, \mathbf{e}_2)$ where $\mathbf{e}_0, \mathbf{e}_1, \mathbf{e}_2 \in \mathbb{F}_2^n \times \mathbb{F}_2^n \times \mathbb{F}_2^n$, we ask $w_H(\mathbf{e}_0) = w_H(\mathbf{e}_2) = w_0$ and $w_H(\mathbf{e}_1) = w_1$. We call this problem as UQCSD(n, w_0, w_1) problem.*

If $w_0 = w_1$, it is obvious that the UQCSD problem is equivalent with 3-QCSD problem. Otherwise, we make a reduction in [Theorem 4](#).

Theorem 4. *If an adversary is able to solve UQCSD(n, w_0, w_1) with advantage ε , then we can construct an adversary solving a 3-QCSD($n, (2w_0 + w_1)/3$) problem with advantage ε' , where $\varepsilon' = \frac{\binom{n}{w_0}^2 \binom{n}{w_1}}{\binom{3n}{2w_0 + w_1}} \varepsilon$.*

Proof. Let $\mathcal{A}$ be the adversary for UQCSD(n, w_0, w_1), we then construct $\mathcal{A}'$ for a 3-QCSD problem. We denote $w = (2w_0 + w_1)/3$ and assume w is an integer without loss of generality. Given an instance $(\mathbf{H}, \mathbf{s})$ of a 3-QCSD(n, w) problem, we then generate a random permutation matrix $\mathbf{P} \in \mathbb{F}_2^{3n \times 3n}$. The adversary $\mathcal{A}'$ call the oracle of $\mathcal{A}$ to solve the UQCSD(n, w_0, w_1) with the input of $(\mathbf{H}\mathbf{P}, \mathbf{s})$. Let $\mathbf{e}$ be the answer of the 3-QCSD problem and $(\mathbf{e}'_0, \mathbf{e}'_1, \mathbf{e}'_2) \leftarrow \mathbf{P}\mathbf{e}$. Let $\mathbf{B}$ be the event of $w_H(\mathbf{e}'_0) = w_H(\mathbf{e}'_2) = w_0$ and $w_H(\mathbf{e}'_1) = w_1$. When $\mathbf{B}$ occurs, the instance $(\mathbf{H}\mathbf{P}, \mathbf{s})$ is a standard UQCSD problem thus $\mathcal{A}$ could solve it with advantage ε .

Now we only need to calculate the probability of event $\mathbf{B}$. Since $\mathbf{P}$ is a random permutation matrix, we have $\Pr(\mathbf{B}) = \frac{\binom{n}{w_0}^2 \binom{n}{w_1}}{\binom{3n}{2w_0 + w_1}}$. As a result, the advantage of

$$\mathcal{A}' \text{ is } \varepsilon' = \frac{\binom{n}{w_0}^2 \binom{n}{w_1}}{\binom{3n}{2w_0 + w_1}} \varepsilon.$$

□

7.2 Security Assumption

The security of our scheme relies on the 2-DQCSD-P problem and 3-DUQCSD-PT problem. These problems are variants of QCSD and UQCSD problems, while the introduced conditions of parity and truncation aim at avoiding trivial distinguishers.

Let $\mathbb{F}_{2,b_1}^n = \{\mathbf{h} \in \mathbb{F}_2^n \mid w_H(\mathbf{h}) = b_1 \bmod 2\}$, i.e., all binary vectors with length n and parity b_1 . Let

$$\mathbb{F}_{2,b_1}^{n \times 2n} = \{\mathbf{H} = (\mathbf{I}_n, \text{rot}(\mathbf{h})) \in \mathbb{F}_2^{n \times 2n} \mid \mathbf{h} \in \mathbb{F}_{2,b_1}^n\}, \text{ and}$$

$$\mathbb{F}_{2,b_1,b_2}^{2n \times 3n} = \left\{ \mathbf{H} = \begin{pmatrix} \mathbf{I}_n & \mathbf{0} & \text{rot}(\mathbf{h}_1) \\ \mathbf{0} & \mathbf{I}_n & \text{rot}(\mathbf{h}_2) \end{pmatrix} \in \mathbb{F}_2^{2n \times 3n} \mid \mathbf{h}_1 \in \mathbb{F}_{2,b_1}^n, \mathbf{h}_2 \in \mathbb{F}_{2,b_2}^n \right\}.$$

Definition 13 (2-QCSD-P Distribution). Let n, w, b_1 be positive integers and let $b_2 = w + b_1 \times w \bmod 2$. The 2-Quasi-Cyclic Syndrome Decoding with Parity Distribution 2-QCSD-P(n, w, b_1, b_2) samples $\mathbf{H} \in \mathbb{F}_2^{n \times 2n}$ and $\mathbf{e} = (\mathbf{e}_1, \mathbf{e}_2) \xleftarrow{\$} \mathbb{F}_2^{2n}$ such that $w_H(\mathbf{e}_1) = w_H(\mathbf{e}_2) = w$, computes $\mathbf{s}^\top = \mathbf{H}\mathbf{e}^\top$ and outputs $(\mathbf{H}, \mathbf{s}) \in \mathbb{F}_{2,b_1}^{n \times 2n} \times \mathbb{F}_{2,b_2}^n$.

Definition 14 (2-DQCSD-P Problem). Let n, w, b_1 be positive integers and let $b_2 = w + b_1 \times w \bmod 2$. Given $(\mathbf{H}, \mathbf{s}) \in \mathbb{F}_{2,b_1}^{n \times 2n} \times \mathbb{F}_{2,b_2}^n$, the Decisional 2-Quasi-Cyclic Syndrome Decoding with Parity Problem 2-DQCSD-P(n, w, b_1, b_2) asks to decide with non-negligible advantage whether the pair $(\mathbf{H}, \mathbf{s})$ came from the 2-QCSD-P(n, w, b_1, b_2) distribution or uniform distribution over $\mathbb{F}_{2,b_1}^{n \times 2n} \times \mathbb{F}_{2,b_2}^n$.

Definition 15 (3-UQCSD-PT Distribution). Let n, w_0, w_1, b_1, b_2, l be positive integers and let $b_3 = w_0 + b_1 \times w_0 \bmod 2$. Specifically, we define that 3-Unbalanced-Quasi-Cyclic Syndrome Decoding with Parity and Truncation Distribution 3-UQCSD-PT($n, w_0, w_1, b_1, b_2, b_3, l$) samples $\mathbf{H} \xleftarrow{\$} \mathbb{F}_{2,b_1,b_2}^{2n \times 3n}$ and $\mathbf{e} = (\mathbf{e}_0, \mathbf{e}_1, \mathbf{e}_2) \xleftarrow{\$} \mathbb{F}_2^{n \times n \times n}$ such that $w_H(\mathbf{e}_0) = w_H(\mathbf{e}_2) = w_0$ and $w_H(\mathbf{e}_1) = w_1$, computes $\mathbf{s}^T = \mathbf{H}\mathbf{e}^T$ where $\mathbf{s} = (\mathbf{s}_0, \mathbf{s}_1)$ and outputs $(\mathbf{H}, (\mathbf{s}_0, \text{Truncate}(\mathbf{s}_1, l))) \in \mathbb{F}_{2,b_1,b_2}^{2n \times 3n} \times (\mathbb{F}_{2,b_3}^n \times \mathbb{F}_2^{n-l})$.

Definition 16 (3-DUQCSD-PT Problem). Let n, w_0, w_1, b_1, b_2, l be positive integers and let $b_3 = w_0 + b_1 \times w_0 \bmod 2$. Given $(\mathbf{H}, (\mathbf{s}_0, \mathbf{s}_1)) \in \mathbb{F}_{2,b_1,b_2}^{2n \times 3n} \times (\mathbb{F}_{2,b_3}^n \times \mathbb{F}_2^{n-l})$, the Decisional 3-Unbalanced-Quasi-Cyclic Syndrome Decoding with Parity and Truncation Problem 3-DUQCSD-PT($n, w_0, w_1, b_1, b_2, b_3, l$) asks to decide with non-negligible advantage whether $(\mathbf{H}, (\mathbf{s}_0, \mathbf{s}_1))$ comes from the 3-UQCSD-PT($n, w_0, w_1, b_1, b_2, b_3, l$) distribution or the uniform distribution over $\mathbb{F}_{2,b_1,b_2}^{2n \times 3n} \times (\mathbb{F}_{2,b_3}^n \times \mathbb{F}_2^{n-l})$.

7.3 Security Proof

7.3.1 IND-CPA Security

In this section, we prove the IND-CPA security of the HARE-PKE scheme relying the security assumptions in [Section 7.2](#). Let $b_1 = \mathbf{h}(1) \bmod 2$, $b_2 = w + b_1 \times w \bmod 2$ and $b_3 = w_r + b_1 \times w_r \bmod 2$. Let $l_1 = n - n_1 \times n_2$.

Theorem 5. For any IND-CPA adversary $\mathcal{A}$ against the HARE-PKE scheme, there exist adversaries $\mathcal{B}_1$ and $\mathcal{B}_2$ such that:

$$\text{Adv}_{\text{HARE-PKE}}^{\text{IND-CPA}}(\mathcal{A}) \leq \text{Adv}_{2\text{-DQCSD-P}}(\mathcal{B}_1) + \text{Adv}_{3\text{-DUQCSD-PT}}(\mathcal{B}_2). \quad (5)$$

Proof. We divide our proof in 4 stages.

(1) Remove the compression technique. Let HARE-PKE_0 be our PKE scheme without the code compression, i.e., keeping $\mathbf{v}$ instead of $\tilde{\mathbf{m}}, \mathbf{v}_2$ as the ciphertext. Let Game_0 be the IND-CPA game for HARE-PKE_0 and Game_1 be the IND-CPA game for HARE-PKE. For any adversary $\mathcal{A}_1$ against HARE-PKE, we construct $\mathcal{A}_0$ to break the IND-CPA of HARE-PKE_0 . The procedures are as follows.

1. $\mathcal{A}_0$ receives the encryption key $\mathbf{ek}$ from HARE-PKE_0 and sends it to $\mathcal{A}_1$.
2. $\mathcal{A}_0$ gets $(\mathbf{m}_0, \mathbf{m}_1) \leftarrow \mathcal{A}_{1, \text{CHOOSE}}(\mathbf{ek})$ and sends it to the challenger of HARE-PKE_0 .
3. The challenger randomly select $b \xleftarrow{\$} \{0, 1\}, \theta \xleftarrow{\$} \mathcal{B}^{|\theta|}$ and generates $\mathbf{c} \leftarrow \text{HARE-PKE}_0.\text{Encrypt}(\mathbf{ek}, \mathbf{m}_b, \theta)$.
4. Let $(\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v}) \leftarrow \mathbf{c}$, $\mathcal{A}_0$ calculates $\mathbf{v}_1 = \mathbf{v}[0, l_2 - 1]$, $\mathbf{v}_2 = \mathbf{v}[l_2, l_1]$, and $\tilde{\mathbf{m}} = \mathcal{C}_2.\text{Decode}(\mathbf{v}_1)$. Then $\mathcal{A}_0$ sends the challenge ciphertext $(\mathbf{u}, \tilde{\mathbf{m}}, \mathbf{v}_2)$ to $\mathcal{A}_1$.
5. $\mathcal{A}_0$ outputs the guess bit b' received by $\mathcal{A}_1$.

The transformation from $(\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v})$ to $(\mathbf{u}, \tilde{\mathbf{m}}, \mathbf{v}_2)$ is a publicly computable mapping requiring no secret information. Since $\mathcal{A}_0$ applies the exact compression defined in HARE-PKE, the challenge ciphertext provided to $\mathcal{A}_1$ is identically distributed to a real ciphertext in HARE-PKE. Thus, $\mathcal{A}_1$ has a perfectly identical view in the reduction as in the real IND-CPA game, which directly implies:

$$\text{Adv}_{\text{HARE-PKE}}^{\text{IND-CPA}}(\mathcal{A}_1) = \text{Adv}_{\text{HARE-PKE}_0}^{\text{IND-CPA}}(\mathcal{A}_0). \quad (6)$$

(2) Replace the encryption key. We first define the game against HARE-PKE_0 . For the sake of simplicity, we use the vector $\mathbf{h}$ as part of the encryption key instead of the seed to generate it.

Game₁(λ)
1. $\text{seed}_{\text{PKE}} \xleftarrow{\\$} \mathcal{B}^{ \text{seed}_{\text{PKE}} }$ 2. $(\mathbf{ek}_{\text{PKE}}, \mathbf{dk}_{\text{PKE}}) \leftarrow \text{HARE-PKE}_0.\text{Keygen}(\text{seed}_{\text{PKE}})$ 3. $(\mathbf{m}_0, \mathbf{m}_1) \leftarrow \mathcal{A}_{\text{CHOOSE}}(\mathbf{ek}_{\text{PKE}})$ 4. $b \xleftarrow{\\$} \{0, 1\}, \theta \xleftarrow{\\$} \mathcal{B}^{ \theta }$ 5. $\mathbf{c}_{\text{PKE}} \leftarrow \text{HARE-PKE}_0.\text{Encrypt}(\mathbf{ek}_{\text{PKE}}, \mathbf{m}_b, \theta)$ 6. $b' \leftarrow \mathcal{A}_{\text{GUESS}}(\mathbf{ek}_{\text{PKE}}, \mathbf{c}_{\text{PKE}})$ 7. return $(b = b')$

Then we forget the decryption key $\mathbf{dk}_{\text{PKE}}$, replace $\mathbf{s}$ of the encryption key with a random vector with parity b_2 , and construct Game_2 with other steps unchanged.

Game₂(λ)
1. $\text{seed}_{\text{PKE}} \xleftarrow{\\$} \mathcal{B}^{ \text{seed}_{\text{PKE}} }$ 2. $(\text{ek}_{\text{PKE}}, \text{dk}_{\text{PKE}}) \leftarrow \text{HARE-PKE}_0.\text{Keygen}(\text{seed}_{\text{PKE}})$ 3. $\mathbf{s} \xleftarrow{\\$} \mathbb{F}_{2, b_2}^n$ 4. $(\text{ek}_{\text{PKE}}, \text{dk}_{\text{PKE}}) \leftarrow ((\text{seed}_{\text{PKE.ek}}, \mathbf{s}), \mathbf{0})$ 5. $(\mathbf{m}_0, \mathbf{m}_1) \leftarrow \mathcal{A}_{\text{CHOOSE}}(\text{ek}_{\text{PKE}})$ 6. $b \xleftarrow{\\$} \{0, 1\}, \theta \xleftarrow{\\$} \mathcal{B}^{ \theta }$ 7. $\text{c}_{\text{PKE}} \leftarrow \text{HARE-PKE}_0.\text{Encrypt}(\text{ek}_{\text{PKE}}, \mathbf{m}_b, \theta)$ 8. $b' \leftarrow \mathcal{A}_{\text{GUESS}}(\text{ek}_{\text{PKE}}, \text{c}_{\text{PKE}})$ 9. return $(b = b')$

Suppose there exists an adversary $\mathcal{B}_1$ which is able to distinguish Game_1 and Game_2 with advantage ε under security parameter λ . Then we construct an adversary to solve the 2-DQCSD-P problem with the same advantage.

Adversary against 2-DQCSD-P($\mathbf{H}, \mathbf{s}$)
1. Compute $\mathbf{h}$ from $\mathbf{H} = (\mathbf{I}_n, \text{rot}(\mathbf{h}))$ 2. Set $\text{ek}_{\text{PKE}} \leftarrow (\mathbf{h}, \mathbf{s})$ 3. Get $\mathbf{m}_0, \mathbf{m}_1 \leftarrow \mathcal{B}_{1, \text{CHOOSE}}(\text{ek}_{\text{PKE}})$ 4. Sample $b \xleftarrow{\\$} \{0, 1\}$ and $\theta \xleftarrow{\\$} \mathcal{B}^{ \theta }$ 5. Compute $\text{c}_{\text{PKE}} \leftarrow \text{HARE-PKE}_0.\text{Encrypt}(\text{ek}_{\text{PKE}}, \mathbf{m}_b, \theta)$ 6. Get $b' \leftarrow \mathcal{B}_{1, \text{GUESS}}(\text{ek}_{\text{PKE}}, \text{c}_{\text{PKE}})$ 7. If $b' = \text{Game}_1$, output 2-QCSD-P(n, w, b_1, b_2) distribution 8. If $b' = \text{Game}_2$, output $\mathcal{U}(\mathbb{F}_{2, b_1}^{n \times 2n} \times \mathbb{F}_{2, b_2}^n)$ distribution

The only difference between Game_1 and Game_2 is the distribution of $(\mathbf{h}, \mathbf{s})$. Thus, the advantage ε of distinguishing Game_1 and Game_2 is precisely the advantage $\text{Adv}_{2\text{-DQCSD-P}}$ of distinguishing the distribution of $(\mathbf{h}, \mathbf{s})$ from the random distribution.

(3) Replace the ciphertext. Then we construct Game_3 by replacing the ciphertext. Instead of sampling $\mathbf{r}_1, \mathbf{r}_2, \mathbf{e}$ with correct weight, we pick random vectors with expected parity.

Game₃(λ)
1. $\text{seed}_{\text{PKE}} \xleftarrow{\\$} \mathcal{B}^{ \text{seed}_{\text{PKE}} }$ 2. $(\mathbf{ek}_{\text{PKE}}, \mathbf{dk}_{\text{PKE}}) \leftarrow \text{HARE-PKE}_0.\text{Keygen}(\text{seed}_{\text{PKE}})$ 3. $\mathbf{s} \xleftarrow{\\$} \mathbb{F}_{2,b_2}^n$ 4. $(\mathbf{ek}_{\text{PKE}}, \mathbf{dk}_{\text{PKE}}) \leftarrow ((\text{seed}_{\text{PKE.ek}}, \mathbf{s}), \mathbf{0})$ 5. $(\mathbf{m}_0, \mathbf{m}_1) \leftarrow \mathcal{A}_{\text{CHOOSE}}(\mathbf{ek}_{\text{PKE}})$ 6. $b \xleftarrow{\\$} \{0, 1\}$ 7. $\mathbf{e} \xleftarrow{\\$} \mathbb{F}_2^n, (\mathbf{r}_1, \mathbf{r}_2) \xleftarrow{\\$} \mathbb{F}_{2,w_r}^n \times \mathbb{F}_{2,w_r}^n$ 8. $\mathbf{u} \leftarrow \mathbf{r}_1 + \mathbf{h}\mathbf{r}_2$ 9. $\mathbf{v} \leftarrow \mathbf{m}_b \mathbf{G}_1 + \text{Truncate}(\mathbf{s}\mathbf{r}_2 + \mathbf{e}, l_1)$ 10. $\mathbf{c}_{\text{PKE}} \leftarrow (\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v})$ 11. $b' \leftarrow \mathcal{A}_{\text{GUESS}}(\mathbf{ek}_{\text{PKE}}, \mathbf{c}_{\text{PKE}})$ 12. return $(b = b')$

Suppose there exists an adversary $\mathcal{B}_2$ which is able to distinguish **Game₂** and **Game₃** with advantage ε under security parameter λ . Then we construct an adversary to solve the 3-DUQCSD-PT problem with the same advantage.

Adversary against 3-DUQCSD-PT($\mathbf{H}, (\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v})$)
1. Compute $\mathbf{h}$ and $\mathbf{s}$ from $\mathbf{H} = \begin{pmatrix} \mathbf{I}_n & \mathbf{0} & \text{rot}(\mathbf{h}) \\ \mathbf{0} & \mathbf{I}_n & \text{rot}(\mathbf{s}) \end{pmatrix}$ 2. Compute $\mathbf{ek}_{\text{PKE}} \leftarrow (\mathbf{h}, \mathbf{s})$ 3. Get $(\mathbf{m}_0, \mathbf{m}_1) \leftarrow \mathcal{B}_{2,\text{CHOOSE}}(\mathbf{ek}_{\text{PKE}})$ 4. Sample $b \xleftarrow{\\$} \{0, 1\}$ 5. Compute $\mathbf{c}_{\text{PKE}} \leftarrow (\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{m}_b \mathbf{G}_1 + \mathbf{v})$ 6. Get $b' \leftarrow \mathcal{B}_{2,\text{GUESS}}(\mathbf{ek}_{\text{PKE}}, \mathbf{c}_{\text{PKE}})$ 7. If $b' = \text{Game}_2$, output 3-UQCSD-PT($n, w_0, w_1, b_1, b_2, b_3, l$) distribution 8. If $b' = \text{Game}_3$, output $\mathcal{U}(\mathbb{F}_{2,b_1,b_2}^{2n \times 3n} \times (\mathbb{F}_{2,b_3}^n \times \mathbb{F}_2^{n-l}))$ distribution

With

$$(\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v} - \mathbf{m}_b \mathbf{G}_1)^\top = ((\mathbf{I}_n \ \mathbf{0} \ \text{rot}(\mathbf{h})) \cdot (\mathbf{r}_1 \ \mathbf{e} \ \mathbf{r}_2)^\top, \text{Truncate}((\mathbf{0} \ \mathbf{I}_n \ \text{rot}(\mathbf{s})) \cdot (\mathbf{r}_1 \ \mathbf{e} \ \mathbf{r}_2)^\top, \ell)),$$

the only difference between **Game₂** and **Game₃** lies in the pair

$$\left(\begin{pmatrix} \mathbf{I}_n & \mathbf{0} & \text{rot}(\mathbf{h}) \\ \mathbf{0} & \mathbf{I}_n & \text{rot}(\mathbf{s}) \end{pmatrix}, (\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v} - \mathbf{m}_b \mathbf{G}_1) \right)$$

follows the 3-DUQCSD-PT($n, w_0, w_1, b_1, b_2, b_3, l$) distribution or a uniform distribution with parity over $\mathbb{F}_{2,b_1,b_2}^{2n \times 3n} \times (\mathbb{F}_{2,b_3}^n \times \mathbb{F}_2^{n-l})$. As a result, the advantage of solving 3-DUQCSD-PT is the same as the advantage of $\mathcal{B}_2$.

(4) Conclusion. In **Game₃**, since $\mathbf{u}$ is computed independently of the challenge bit b and $\mathbf{v}$ is masked by a random vector $\mathbf{e}$, the advantage on **Game₃** is $\frac{1}{2}$.

With the previous proof chain, we have

$$\begin{aligned}
\text{Adv}_{\text{HARE-PKE}}^{\text{IND-CPA}}(\mathcal{A}) &= \text{Adv}_{\text{HARE-PKE}_0}^{\text{IND-CPA, Game}_1}(\mathcal{A}) \\
&\leq \text{Adv}_{2\text{-DQCS-D-P}}(\mathcal{B}_1) + \text{Adv}_{\text{HARE-PKE}_0}^{\text{IND-CPA, Game}_2}(\mathcal{A}) \\
&\leq \text{Adv}_{2\text{-DQCS-D-P}}(\mathcal{B}_1) + \text{Adv}_{3\text{-DUQCS-D-PT}}(\mathcal{B}_2) + \text{Adv}_{\text{HARE-PKE}_0}^{\text{IND-CPA, Game}_3}(\mathcal{A}) \\
&= \text{Adv}_{2\text{-DQCS-D-P}}(\mathcal{B}_1) + \text{Adv}_{3\text{-DUQCS-D-PT}}(\mathcal{B}_2).
\end{aligned}$$

which completes the proof. $\square$

7.3.2 IND-CCA2 Security

By constructing HARE-KEM with the salted Fujisaki-Okamoto transform [6,7,10], we prove the IND-CCA2 security of HARE-KEM.

Considering the DFR of schemes, we give the following definitions which guarantee δ -correct.

Definition 17 (δ -correct PKE [7]). *A PKE is δ -correct if:*

$$\mathbb{E} \left(\max_{\mathbf{m} \in \mathcal{M}} \Pr [\text{PKE.Decrypt}(\mathbf{dk}_{\text{PKE}}, \mathbf{c}_{\text{PKE}}) \neq \mathbf{m} \mid \mathbf{c}_{\text{PKE}} \leftarrow \text{PKE.Encrypt}(\mathbf{ek}_{\text{PKE}}, \mathbf{m})] \right) \leq \delta. \quad (9)$$

where the expectation is taken over $(\mathbf{ek}_{\text{PKE}}, \mathbf{dk}_{\text{PKE}}) \leftarrow \text{PKE.Keygen}()$.

Definition 18 (δ -correct KEM [7]). *A KEM is δ -correct if:*

$$\Pr \left[\text{KEM.Decaps}(\mathbf{dk}_{\text{KEM}}, \mathbf{c}_{\text{KEM}}) \neq \mathbf{K} \mid \begin{array}{l} (\mathbf{ek}_{\text{KEM}}, \mathbf{dk}_{\text{KEM}}) \leftarrow \text{KEM.Keygen}(); \\ (\mathbf{K}, \mathbf{c}_{\text{KEM}}) \leftarrow \text{KEM.Encaps}(\mathbf{ek}_{\text{KEM}}) \end{array} \right] \leq \delta. \quad (7)$$

In HARE-PKE and HARE-KEM, the δ is upper bounded by the analysis of DFR in Section 6. Thus, we can upper bound the advantage of HARE-KEM in Theorem 6 by combining the Theorem 13 from [10] and the result in Theorem 5.

Theorem 6. *If HARE-PKE is δ -correct, for any IND-CCA2 adversary $\mathcal{A}$ against the HARE-KEM scheme issuing at most q_{RO} queries to $\mathbf{G}$ and q_D queries to the HARE-KEM.Decaps oracle, there exists adversaries $\mathcal{B}_1$ and $\mathcal{B}_2$ such that:*

$$\begin{aligned}
\text{Adv}_{\text{HARE-KEM}}^{\text{IND-CCA2}}(\mathcal{A}) &\leq \frac{1}{2^{|\mathbf{K}|} \cdot 2^{|\text{salt}|}} + \frac{3q_{RO}}{2^{|\mathbf{K}|}} + (q_{RO} + q_D) \cdot \delta \\
&\quad + 2 \cdot (\text{Adv}_{2\text{-DQCS-D-P}}(\mathcal{B}_1) + \text{Adv}_{3\text{-DUQCS-D-PT}}(\mathcal{B}_2)).
\end{aligned} \quad (13)$$

7.3.3 Known Attacks

We categorize the potential attacks into two main categories. First, **structural attacks** exploit the cyclic properties of quasi-cyclic codes when $X^n - 1$ possesses

low-degree factors[9,13]. To mitigate these threats, we select n as a primitive prime, ensuring that the polynomial $X^n - 1$ has only two irreducible factors. Consequently, such structural attacks cannot be efficiently applied to our scheme.

Second, we consider attacks targeting the 2-DQCSD-P and 3-DUQCSD-PT problems. The most efficient methods for solving the Syndrome Decoding (SD) problem are Information Set Decoding (ISD) algorithms, such as those presented in [17,20,15,2]. These algorithms remain applicable to 2-DQCSD-P and 3-DUQCSD-PT. In the quasi-cyclic setting, a speed-up via the Decoding One Out of Many (DOOM) technique [18] should be accounted for, where the complexity gain is $O(\sqrt{n})$ for both 2-DQCSD-P and 3-DUQCSD-PT. We use the open-source estimator from [21] to evaluate the concrete bit security of these problems, with the results shown in Table 4.

Instance	Problem	Prange [17]	Stern [20]	BJMM [2]	Target Security
HARE-1	3-DUQCSD-PT	154	137	134	128
	2-DQCSD-P	164	145	143	
HARE-3	3-DUQCSD-PT	223	204	201	192
	2-DQCSD-P	235	213	211	
HARE-5	3-DUQCSD-PT	287	266	263	256
	2-DQCSD-P	299	275	273	

Table 4: The ISD bit-security of HARE parameter sets.

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Appendix

A Experiments for erasure decoding of RM codes

To verify our estimation in [Theorem 1](#), we make experiments under different thresholds α and error probability p . Specifically, we repeat $N = 10^6$ decoding procedures in duplicated RM[384, 8, 192]. In each parameter set of [Table 5](#), the theoretical upper bound is larger than the simulation result.

α	$P_{\text{error}}^{\text{theory}}$	$P_{\text{error}}^{\text{simulate}}$	$P_{\text{erasure}}^{\text{theory}}$	$P_{\text{erasure}}^{\text{simulate}}$
$p = 0.34$				
5	0.000973	0.000075	0.002465	0.002150
7	0.000047	0.000032	0.004386	0.003808
9	0.000022	0.000010	0.007508	0.006555
$p = 0.35$				
5	0.000403	0.000267	0.007631	0.006344
7	0.000206	0.000103	0.012763	0.010782
9	0.000102	0.000050	0.020529	0.017607

Table 5: Theoretical and simulation probability of decoding error and erasure for different p .